

BEYOND BRITE RETREAT
May 19-21
Session One: Who Are You?
(90 Minutes)

9:15
1 Introductions (RACHEL)

Housekeeping, likely with Lizette leading. Include invitation to move your body around the room as helps you remain in your body & present in the moment. *Shoane & Jenny*

+ options, by lunch

What is your name? What kind of ministry you seek? If currently serving, where and in what role?

- Rachel (Model brevity)
- Dale (Model brevity)
- Lizette (Unnecessary, but leaving her out feels wrong.)
- 9 Participants

We Are Two Voices – Not the ONLY Two Voices (DALE & RACHEL)

- (DALE) "Scholars Disagree" story about Dr. Ambrose Edens.
- Our invitation is not to agree with me or to agree with Rachel.
- Our invitation is to listen to two voices that you may not have heard.
 - My voice is born out of 38 years of post-seminary ministry in a variety of settings.
 - It is a voice that knows what it is to thrive in church, what it is to be crushed by church, what it is to leave the church, and what it is to be loved by church so much that I could not help but fall back in love with God.
 - It is a voice from someone who was fully immersed in "the institution" of the church for 33 years. And it is a voice that for the last 11 years has walked a path along with other spiritual pilgrims that is so unconventional and so fluid in being unconventional that the institutions of the church don't quite know what to do with us . . . and yet at the same time the leaders of these institutions experience who we are and what we do as nothing less than compelling.
 - (RACHEL) My voice is born out of 4 years of post-seminary ministry, primarily in congregations, some in hospital chaplaincy, which absorbed some negativity about the landscape... had boundaries pounded over my head...
 - It is a voice . . . *only to find I'll need more often to trust my instincts in situations more gray*
 - It is a voice that is experiencing the conventions and the challenges of established church ministry while at the same time being a participant-leader in something completely different.
served as associate minister - filling in gaps & part-time: left out of strategy or big picture thinking sometimes frustrated & offended by that. Sometimes honestly glad I don't need to be more exhausted by that

You Are Not Responsible for the Survival of the Church

(DALE) We want to begin by examining the veracity of a statement.

True or False: "You are responsible for the survival of the church."

- 9:20
- Check In
 - Anyone been told that? (By whom?)
 - Anyone thought that? (When?)
 - Anyone felt that? (What does that feel like?)
 - (RACHEL) This statement is false. In fact, it is based on a whole series of fallacies.

Any thoughts on what those might be?

Let's look at three together.

- Fallacy: Faith in God and Belief in Jesus as the Son of God is in decline.
 - The Center for the Study of Global Christianity at Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary recently reported that global Christianity is experiencing remarkable growth, defying expectations and surpassing population rates.

Contrary to the anticipated slowdown, the Christian population is projected to climb from over 2.52 billion to over 3 billion by 2050.

The growth of Christianity is particularly pronounced in the global south, with Africa and Asia emerging as the fastest-growing regions.

- Even in the United States, while church membership has been declining, "faith" is not in freefall. in CPE
 - In 2022, 81% of US residents believed in God. Down 10 percentage points since 2002 ~~years~~. *(Lots of time for a recovery.)*
20 years ago
 - In 2022, 56% believe Jesus is the Son of God (or God). Down 4% percentage points 2015.
 - Church attendance decline has also slowed and is holding at a consistent 40% rate since the pandemic. The New York Times had an interesting article recently called "Americans Haven't Found a Satisfying Alternative to Religion" By Lauren Jackson.

- ○ Fallacy: You have the power to save the church . . . or even the congregation you serve. *the young people young pastor myth*
- ○ Fallacy: Clergy bear the sole responsibility or the bulk of the responsibility for the health and wellbeing of the church.
it can really feel like this ~~was~~

~~OPEN CONVERSATION~~

• (DALE) Three Truths to Free Your Heart:

9:30

- Truth: You are called to love the people, not the institution. The people are the church . . . both the people who are there and the people who are not there yet. This is evangelism in its truest form. (Tacitus???) *look how they show their love for one another - early church*
- Truth: Institutions like your congregation and your denomination have life cycles. Like a tree, they are born, and they die. And then they are reborn, and they die. YOU cannot change that. But WE can savor every moment along the way. *not stress out about it*
- Truth: The ministry you are doing right now, matters, right now. In fact, this ministry will always be valuable because it matters, right now. Its value has nothing to do with the longevity of your congregation or your agency or your seminary or your denomination.

(DALE tells the story of his father.)

(DALE references "Avengers: Age of Ultron" – Vision says to Ultron, "A thing doesn't have to last in order to be beautiful." *like a living rose*)

(DALE witnesses to the grace of being able to say, "This is beautiful. It is enough.)

9:45
9:55
~~9:55~~
OPEN CONVERSATIONThe Philosophical and Sociological Marker of Our Time

(RACHEL) In 2007, Canadian philosopher, Dr. Charles Taylor, published a landmark book entitled, "A Secular Age." It is a 776-page slog that is not for the faint of heart. But theologians who have wrestled with it discovered at least one takeaway that leaders of the church should know. *to be clear he is the one who read it. he was fascinated but what he told me about it resonated*

In Western Civilization, the primary philosophical brokenness and sociological pathology that is diminishing the life of the human family is **the loss of a sense of transcendence. We no longer experience a connection with a power that is larger and beyond themselves.** *loss of symbolization - ken Lorenz Lawrence*

The problem inherent to this loss of a sense of transcendence is that human beings aren't designed to exist without an experienced connection with a power larger and beyond themselves. Philosophically, this experienced connection has always been a part of who human existence. (We in the church might call this experienced connection an aspect of "imago dei.")

*humans aren't designed to function without
i think folks are looking... in astrology tarot crystals
& sometimes our churches can feel embarrassed or hesitant
to embrace the message of God's trans or share it church hurt*

(DALE) Because of this loss of a sense of transcendence, Taylor predicts an acceleration of the influence of celebrity . . . a culture of personality. More and more, people will be drawn to individuals who they perceive not only as successful but also live lives beyond the confines of the rules which binds themselves and everyone else.

And . . . AND . . . I would argue that those individuals who portray an image of lavish success, who do so while blatantly disregarding accepted social convention, and who prove to be beyond the reach of the consequences we have come to expect for this behavior . . . these individuals will be (and unfortunately one now is) the ultimate embodiment of this culture of personality . . . or should I say this cult of personality.

Implications for the Church

(RACHEL) Dr. Andrew Root has written prolifically on the implications that the loss of a sense of transcendence has for the church. ^{2/07 cult of the church this place its traditions longevity nostalgia} The book we recommend is a summary presentation of his larger work called, "When the Church Stop Working." Co-Authoring by Blair Bertrand, this book quite simply asks: "What do you do when your church stops working?" ^{In his "ministry in a secular age" series the accessible shorter work is called "When the Church Stops Working"} The answer? Any thoughts? According to Root and Bertrand, when your church stops working, then stop working!

Pause. Put a stop to all the busy-ness. ^{isn't busy-ness all we've doing elsewhere? what's different & transcendent about} Hold liminal space for one another. Together, ^{are we just reproducing?} sit at the feet of Jesus, and wait. Forget the mission statement. Put aside the 5-year plan. Instead, listen for God's invitation to your congregation in this time and this place. And then, and only then, open a prayerful dialogue with God and one another in order to discern the next act of faithful creativity your congregation will embody in Christ's name.

^{"active waiting"}

(DALE) I would put it this way. The most important task before church leaders is helping their people to experience the transcendence of God, to savor God's presence, and to ground themselves in that presence – to know in their bones individually and collectively that the One they know as The Beloved knows them as beloved as well. In fact, the One who is the Source and Sustainer of all things, the One who holds the vastness of the universe and each individual atom in it, the One whose nature and very being was revealed in the person of Jesus . . . this God delights in their presence!

Over the last decade, I have come to believe that compassion, particularly the compassion of Christ, is the only life-generating source of inspiration, motivation, and action that is sustainable over time. Dissatisfaction, anger, rage, and even the horror of witnessing the violation of others will get you off your butt and get you moving. But if nurtured over time, they become toxic and even pathological -- towards oneself and others.

And the first step in embodying the Compassion of Christ, choosing this boundless and relentless as a way of life, is learning to be grounded in Sacred Presence we know as The Beloved and who knows us as beloved as well.

^{Does the church need to be needed to be effective?}

(shortening)

9:50

Implications for Ministry

(DALE) If this is the case, and I firmly believe it is, then the most important task before you and me as leaders of the church is to model what it means to experience the transcendence of God, to savor God's presence, and to be grounded in the experience of this Sacred Presence.

~~9:55~~ **Pause** Your first priority as a minister of the Gospel of Jesus Christ is to know in your bones that "You are a beloved child of God. God delights in you!" w Paul Jones theological worlds

There Is GOOD NEWS

10:00 (RACHEL) We bring you GOOD NEWS! YOU CAN develop a Deep Christian

Spirituality! have you been taught how? have you put it in practice? honest, own where you are.

And you can take your first and maybe most important step while you are here at this retreat . . . recognize and own that you have not been taught to how.

You've certainly been taught how to produce excellently within the last two years, and for some, within the last two weeks, you finally completed 20+ years of being told that your value is tied to your ability to produce and to do so with excellence. Congratulations are in order. Well done, good and faithful servants!

Amazing! to think through tough issues, to talk talk about the church today, get broken & disembodied! maybe even to tie yourself

At the same time, we should be aware that there has been a consistent and persistent and often unperceived subtext being taught throughout your academic career.

but maybe you find your spirit tied up in knots, you feel you're always hustling for your worthiness, not sure where it lies.

20th century theologian, Dr. Henri Nouwen, in a televised reflection on his book, "Life of the Beloved," puts it this way:

The basic question before us as human beings is, "Who are we?" And that's what keeps us going. Throughout our lives, we are constantly asking, "Who am I?"

[Our culture teaches us to answer that question in three ways:]

1. I am what I do.
2. I am what I have . . . which is another way of saying . . . I am what I achieve because of what I do.
3. I am what others say about me.

Rachel 10:05 Story 21st century theologian, Dr. Tricia Hersey, in her book, "Rest Is Resistance," calls this "Grind Culture." Hersey explains that Grind Culture is a culturally indoctrinated self-perception that each of us is a machine, a piece of equipment in a cultural and economic assembly line, valued according to its ability to produce and to produce with excellence.

(Reflections on first years of ministry, getting caught in grind culture. Always had been wondering "what is ministry," forgot "ministry is not what you do but how you do it," remembering "who are you" with God)

over

(DALE) Whether you like it or not, your behavior has been consistently reinforced, positively and negatively, in ways that have taught you to equate your value with what you do, what you achieve, and what others say about you.

And what do you suppose is the most pervasive and proficient indoctrinator of "Grind Culture" in the United States and much of the Western World? Our education system.

And I know that you have been taught this value system because you are good at it! Actually, you are very good at it, or you wouldn't be here today.

Don't get us wrong. We believe education is important. The excellence with which you have navigated its demands of you makes a difference. And one measure of your success should be the feedback you receive from your teachers and professors.

We are just pointing out that you have just recently completed 20+ years of being taught how to produce . . . and to produce well. And now, you have been thrust into a role where your top priority is to be still, to experience Sacred Presence, and to know in your bones that you are a beloved child of God. But no one has taught you how.

Turn & Talk with a partner or two: how has grind culture shown up for you so far in your ministry? What does it cause within you? To what ministry results does it seem to lead?

- an honest assessment, trying not to be too judgmental. Acknowledging it's here, knowing we have feelings about it & naming those. Then trying to explore where it gets us or what it does.

More Good News.

(RACHEL) **We bring you more GOOD NEWS!** You can learn how. You have proven beyond a shadow of a doubt that you are teachable.

And there are many spiritual practices that can ground you and nurture your ability to savor God's presence:

- Centering Prayer
- Breath Prayers
- The Jesus Prayer
- Lectio, Visio, Audio, and Personae Divinae
- Intersectional Bible Study
- Labyrinth Walking
- Journaling
- The Compassion Practice that Dale and I teach.

we have to be reminded
(everything else is so loud)
(everything else is not my
felt ~~agitated~~ ministry is the first step)

shake it
off!

10:20

10:30

(DALE) We encourage you to explore the historic spiritual practices of the church and the newer practices that are grounded in the historic practices of the church. (For instance, the Compassion Practice is firmly rooted in Ignatian spirituality, informed by Buddhist practices in loving all things, Sufi practices in unconditional welcoming, and post-modern self-healing practices like Internal Family Systems, and illustrated through narrative pedagogy.)

Then, practice the practice. Religiously. That means practicing the practice a minimum of 5 days a week, 50 weeks a year.

If you choose this path, then we highly recommend that you invest in Spiritual Direction. You will need a guide who understands the dynamics and pitfalls of nurturing a deep Christian spirituality.

And if you discover that the transition to making spiritual practice a part of your daily life is difficult (which it is for most people), then find an accountability buddy. This is a trusted person with whom you covenant to call or facetime or Zoom at a specific time . . . and for 15 to 20 minutes . . . each of you practices a spiritual practice of your own choosing . . . on your own . . . without interaction . . . but at the same time.

I know. It sounds weird. But it works.

10:35 OPEN DISCUSSION

or start w/ small in the moment pieces
find a routine. this is not another do list checkbox item (which I'm so good at)

10:45 end Resources

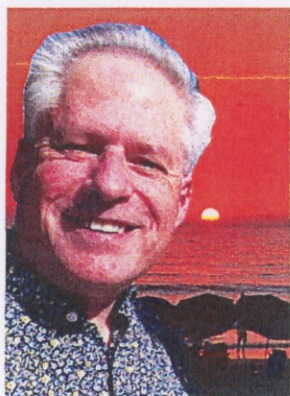
The New York Times, "Americans Haven't Found a Satisfying Alternative to Religion" by Lauren Jackson, April 18, 2025

shake it off! b4 smt grp

4 Pivots link from Faith + Lead : the folks at Luther Seminary are looking at shifts in needs & role of the church in our society & time too. They suggest "4 pivots" to be made in focus & practice:

- From fixing institutions to discerning God's leading
- From membership to discipleship
- To a mixed ecology of ministry settings including traditional congregations & new forms
- From clergy-led, lay-supported to lay-led, clergy-supported

MEET YOUR FACILITATORS



The Rev. Dale Suggs earned a BA in Religion Studies and Computer Science from Texas Christian University ('83) and a MDiv from Brite Divinity School ('87). He holds Graduate Certificates in Ecumenical Studies from the University of Geneva ('88) and Spiritual Direction from the University of San Diego ('07). He also is a Certified Facilitator of the Compassion Practice through Claremont School of Theology ('16).

Dale is an ordained minister in the Christian Church (Disciples of Christ). He has served as Senior Minister in 3 congregation in Indiana and Southern California, as Intentional Interim Minister in 4 congregations in Southern California and Arizona, and as a Hospice Chaplain in San Diego.

In 2018, Dale and his wife, Shelly (CST '17), co-founded an alternative-model congregation based in San Diego called **BELOVED** Way. Grounded in grace, inclusion and compassion, BW is organized around spiritual practice and engages in compassion-based outreach especially in mental health.

In 2020, Dale and Shelly also co-founded the nonprofit, **BELOVED** Compassion Network. BCN facilitates spiritual practices that provide the "how to" of "making compassion a way of life" for individuals, teams and organizations. BCN also offers online support groups for trauma care.

Dale is a teacher, speaker, and retreat leader specializing in compassion, spiritual practice, and "breaking the silence" about mental health in the church. He provides Spiritual Direction for students at Disciple Seminary Foundation and Phillips Theological Seminary. Dale and Shelly will celebrate 42 years of marriage in August. They have 4 beautiful daughters and 4 wondrous granddaughters.



The Rev. Rachel Cooley Shawler is a pastor, sister, sometimes-yogi, spouse, youth mentor, chaplain, and soon-to-be mother. She claims New Mexico as home but grew up all over the US and lived a few years in Germany growing up with a dad in the Air Force. Becoming fascinated by culture & peoples, she majored in Sociology and English Literature during college in San Antonio, before serving as an Americorps member in a high-need, low-income school there.

The challenges of that service plus a major loss in her family led Rachel to deeper church engagement, and she experienced a call to ministry in community there. Vanderbilt Divinity School was next, where the Disciples

House through the Christian Church (Disciples of Christ) instilled a commitment to openness with colleagues and theology explored in community (MDiv '21). Rachel has served 3 churches including one program-sized, one pastor-sized and one family-sized which welcomed queer folks in the otherwise unwelcoming panhandle of Florida.

Rachel's move to San Diego for her husband's medical residency invited hospital chaplaincy training, yoga teacher training, and Compassion Practice experience. In our stressful lives & sometimes callus culture, she refocuses on getting grounded in our bodies and holding space for emotional vulnerability. She continues to be interested in integrating these practices in community life, small groups, and pastoral care. Rachel is now preparing to move to Baltimore, MD and saying goodbye to a pastor-sized United Church of Christ congregation where she's served as Associate Minister of Youth and Community-Building.

As I'm in my 6th year of ministry, and getting ready to close out my service at Kensington UCC in San Diego, I'm in a particularly rich moment for reflecting on where I've grown, yes, but also what I've gotten lost in along the way.

At first, and in the transitional time just after seminary, I was constructing my faith & integrating it into my life & service and it felt good. But the pressures of employment & getting paid & certainly some of my own demons & life difficulties that arose had me kind of lost for a while.

How did I wind up in a place lately where too high a percentage of my work at church is administrative & logistical? And it feels like more time behind the computer is soul-sucking. Not to mention that lots of people don't even answer my emails. How did I wind up feeling like it's wrong for members to ask me about me, especially during this pregnancy, and receive their care graciously & gratefully?

Not taking time to prepare my pieces for worship as much, let alone pray for the people or meditate in the community. Does putting people on the prayer list & sending a note to others about them count as praying? And does that count as my time in my own faith?

For a while about 2 years post-seminary, I kept asking "what is ministry" getting caught in my head or intellectualizing but masking this deeper, desperate feeling. An overwhelming feeling I didn't really want to touch, so I'd just keep busy, keep in my head.

And when my coach pointed it out to me, mostly I'd blame myself, like I should be able to just shake such things off, know that hustling & numbing wasn't part of co-creating with God, I'm a minister for goodness sake.

But she'd remind me, and I had to remind myself over & over that I'd been taught to hustle & intellectualize all my life. And that the church space I was in was forming me by their expectations too, and my unconscious reactions to them, and my grasping for more certainty or comfort in getting things done, planning youth events, reminding folks about meetings. I know some administration is necessary & I'm willing to serve, though, so I'd keep going. A

strange self-sacrificing thing emerged. Which of course I'd also been taught all my life as a woman & youngest sibling & by others around me modeling poor boundaries with work & service to others.

Once I analyzed all this & used reminding myself of the environment as a coping mechanism so I wouldn't blame myself, though, I wound up often stuck in cynicism, with no sense of agency to change it, so I just kept going.

Confirmation... I'd gone to the meetings, collaborated, emailed the families & mentors the plans, and eventually offered an edited but mostly similar format for our Confirmation Service to our folks. Come to find out, one of the youth had felt left behind weeks ago, and it came back to me: I knew the small group in which he shut down & I knew I hadn't really been there for him in that moment, validating his questions in the group & inviting him in. I was so tired that day, I was frustrated with him even, not paying attention more, how I thought he should, to the things that had been prepared for him with difficulty. Now I'm not saying we can't get frustrated with our people. But now he didn't want to present at the service & furthermore he didn't feel he'd gotten much out of the program. His mom had made him come, and I feel I let them down, and she seemed a bit icy with me now too, even as she validated that it's near impossible to even hear what's wrong from him when he shuts down like he had. I felt like I'd lost the thread, the focus on nurturing faith, and so had he. Now he might not have really picked up on it anyway, but it was a moment of reorientation for me.

families don't come to church now for more programming. Their lives are over full. Of course they don't want to respond to my emails, their days are so packed with replying & coordinating anyway.

What do they come for? And what did I get in this for in the first place? I'd gotten so caught in "what is ministry" & hustling that I'd forgotten my seminary reflection that ministry is not so much about *what* you do but *how* you do it.

And I'd forgotten my particular gifts, which are about holding sacred space for vulnerability. Although I'm here to tell you based on my performance review

- relationally, with depth, over time

So easy to critique, we're taught to. What are we building, what are we doing right. it's normal to self doubt and even good to self examine. But it's also good to build ourselves up and remember the intrinsic gifts we have. Sometimes our job descriptions don't feel like they match: we have to find outlets and know that they're gonna come out anyway, through God's spirit thanks be

Early ministry can feel extra vulnerable. Older people are projecting their shit onto us or we want them to be trustworthy leaders but find they're not.

We may want to accept any role we can, we think we can't get to what we want just yet, we need exposure

We need someone to pay us. The scars of capitalism & current wounds/needs. That our value is what we're paid. Learning it's true that people value what they pay for in some ways. But that's not the only thing they value, by God's spirit thanks be.

Knowing you have value, who you are and who's your are and the gifts you intrinsically have & aint nobody gonna get rid of em that's impossible because god made them ... sacred moments, your call

What are my specific gifts / not fitting this mold I think I see laid out for me or is valued by our grind culture brainiac professionalism

We have to be reminded cause they other stuff is so loud

which happened just last week, quite behind schedule but yet offered by the congregation, that my gifts have been shining through anyways. They lifted up how I see people, how my communication responds to their needs, and how I name their unmet/unspoken needs too & attempt to integrate them into what the church does, even if I don't always succeed.

The question is "what is ministry" and how can I fit & succeed, but "who am I" with God, what gifts does God delight in with me.

the good news is that there ain't nothing I can worry about or do that will hide them away completely. I can see that with the benefit of hindsight. But what if I could soak in a sense of my call & God's love with me more often in the present moment? What if I could live it out more fully day to day? and remind myself genuinely & more often that what I offer is enough?

Now I'm not gonna say I'm ...

but the Compassion Practice has offered me
a way

what is the church, Christians
the need is so great

white supremacy culture
force spirituality in itself
invisible to us

transcendence
not God

anti-racism compassion practice

Communal

Ubuntu
I-thou

youth ministry
spirituality project
Mark Yaconelli

Selfish
↓

how do we get back to God?

not that God is 'just some touching feely
feel good

triggers from seminary

Communal healing from whiteness, yes

how do you care for your inner world?
take time to reflect

come back to the feelings in the moment,
Sometimes a momentary pause is all needed
there are other deeper things we ^{don't} realize are
at play

In & out of your role they expect of you
not some kind of must do
the dam, but there's the flow — how God responds
to you